



The Japanese green tea—matcha—is moving from teacups to cocktail shakers, giving Indian mixology a vibrant, healthy twist

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

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Muskan Jhaveri, a New Delhi-based HR consultant, is a self-proclaimed matcha fan. “I fell in love with it on a trip to Japan a few years ago,” she says. She couldn’t find it easily in India till a couple of years ago but now she has it almost daily.

Matcha, meaning ‘powdered tea’, is a vibrant green powder made from tea leaves that are specifically cultivated and processed. Contrary to regular green tea, where the leaves are steeped and discarded, matcha involves consuming the entire leaf, providing a powerful dose of antioxidants, vitamins and minerals. Traditionally used in Japanese tea ceremonies, matcha’s unique flavour profile—a harmony of umami, sweetness and a hint of bitterness—is giving it a global fan following, including in India.

The once elusive matcha is now available at coffee chains, neighbourhood cafes and even bars! “Bartenders love it because it brings umami along with bitterness and pairs well with gins, agave spirits and even sake. It provides a creamy/frothy feel when shaken well, like in a matcha gin sour or a matcha melon ball,” says Vikram Achanta, co-founder and CEO, Tulleeho, a beverage training provider.

Agrees Minakshi Singh, co-founder of three Delhi-NCR based bars—Sidecar, Cocktails and Dreams Speakeasy, and The Brook: “We have experimented with it and used it in classic cocktails such as Margarita and Whisky Sour which have been well received by our guests,” she says, adding that matcha’s health benefits also make it attractive to Gen Z.

A healthy cocktail sounds like an oxymoron but there is no denying that matcha’s supposed health benefits have added to its popularity. Matcha is rich in essential vitamins and minerals such as vitamin A, C, E, K, potassium, calcium and iron. Its antioxi-

1. Hello Stranger, a cocktail by Kolkata’s Little Bit Sober, comes with a garnish of a matcha meringue

2. Mumbai’s The Dimsum Room has reinterpreted the classic Salty Dog cocktail with a matcha layer